

HAL Established 1940

Having manufactured 3,500 aircraft and 3,600 engines of different types, HAL is spreading its wings wider with indigenously designed fighters, trainers and helicopters

HIGH AND MIGHTY

Look at the metal birds in the Indian skies. Chances are the largest defence PSU Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL) has something to do with them. Established by Seth Walchand Hirachand before the government took over in 1942, HAL has over the years built up comprehensive skills in design, manufacture and overhaul of fighters, trainers, helicopters, transport aircraft, avionics and system equipment in its 19 manufacturing divisions across India. HAL is now headed by Ashok Nayak who joined

the company as a management trainee after studying mechanical engineering from Bangalore University in 1973.

From launch vehicles for the Indian Space Research Organisation to joint production of latest fighter aircraft like Su-30MKI, Hawk, Light Combat Aircraft and Dornier Do-228, HAL has a long list of achievements. Along with Dhruv or the Advanced Light Helicopter (ALH) and the Cheetah/Chetak helicopters series, HAL has already begun production of the indige-

nous fighter aircraft Tejas, designed by the Aeronautics Development Agency. Nearly 200 are to be deployed by the Indian Air Force over the next five years. The Russian-made Su-30MKI and UK's Hawk advanced jet trainers are also being produced for the defence forces. Under a multi-billion dollar deal with the Russian Sukhoi combat jetmaker in 2000, HAL will co-produce nearly 250 Sukhoi fighter jets for the Indian Air Force by 2015.

With aviation majors like Airbus and Boeing also outsourcing high-precision structural work packages to HAL, the company is the only Indian aviation giant to become a \$2-billion company, clocking a Rs 421-crore profit during 2008-09 and a sales turnover currently of Rs 11,161 crore—a 27 per cent rise over the previous year. Thanks to a captive clientele in the defence forces, it has an order book worth an incredible Rs 60,000 crore.

Rs 421 crore
is the value of exports HAL has to its name in the financial year 2008-09.

HAL plans to induct its indigenously designed Intermediate Jet Trainer (IJT or Sitara) into service in 2010 to replace the Kiran turbojet currently in operation. The Light

Combat Helicopter (LCH), a dedicated attack helicopter armed with air-to-air and air-to-ground weapons, is expected to have its first test flight later this year, and nearly 200 Light Utility Helicopters (LUH), tailored for reconnaissance and surveillance roles, will be jointly made by HAL to replace the 300-odd Cheetah and Chetak helicopters in service now.

With India's defence offsets policy likely to bring in \$10 billion during the 11th Five-Year Plan, it will look for direct offsets in all capital acquisitions of the Defence Ministry to strengthen the capabilities of indigenous industry. At least 30 per cent of the capital acquisitions under this policy will have to be indigenously made. With most offsets in the aerospace area, HAL, no doubt, will fly high.

by Stephen David



Ashok Nayak 58, Chairman

"Our major thrust is on massive indigenisation programmes and becoming South Asia's largest aviation giant in the next five years."